

# MAKI Tagging — Quick Guide

Each tag answers a distinct question about the photo. Carry one from each facet; intersect in search.

## Principles rules that keep the tag catalogue coherent over years

- 1. Tag in hierarchies.** Separator is |. Ancestors auto-expand: `subject|nature|landscape` also stores `subject|nature` and `subject`.
- 2. Generic lowercase, proper nouns keep case.** `concert` not `Concert`; `Peter Schneider` stays capitalised; `Germany` in English but `München` local.
- 3. One language.** Pick one and stick with it. Place names: English for countries, local from region down.
- 4. Facets are orthogonal.** Independent axes, not nested. Intersect in queries; don't mash into one tree.
- 5. Tag what you see.** Primary tags describe visible content; context goes in secondary tags.
- 6. Don't duplicate metadata.** Camera, lens, date, GPS are EXIF; folders are path. Don't tag them.
- 7. Aim for 5–15 tags per image.** Fewer is poor discoverability; more is usually noise.
- 8. Separate workflow from content.** Ratings / color labels / saved searches for state. Tags for content.

## The Facets one question per axis — any photo can carry a tag from each

*What is in the image?*

`subject|nature|landscape`  
`subject|animal|bird`  
`subject|urban|architecture`  
`subject|person|portrait`  
`subject|performing arts|concert`  
`subject|event|wedding`  
`subject|object|food`  
`subject|mood|dramatic`

*Which specific occasion?*

`event|wedding-jane-2025`  
`event|fuji-trip-2023`  
`event|workshop-la-2019`

Date-driven, grows unboundedly. Flat naming or `event|2025|...`. Separate from `subject|event|*`, which is the generic scene type.

*Where was it taken?*

`location|Germany`  
`location|Germany|Bayern`  
`location|Germany|Bayern|München`  
`location|Germany|Bayern|Gelling|Kulturbühne Hinterhalt`

Countries in English; local names from region down.

*Who is in it?*

`person|family`  
`person|friend|Alice Müller`  
`person|artist|musician|Peter Schneider`  
`person|ensemble|band|Alice Viola Trio`

For large catalogues, consider face recognition instead of manual person tags.

*How was it made?*

`technique|style|black and white`  
`technique|lighting|golden hour`  
`technique|lighting|stage lighting`  
`technique|exposure|long exposure`  
`technique|composition|symmetry`  
`technique|effect|bokeh`

*Which project/assignment?*

`project|365 pictures 2018`  
`project|Bricking Bavaria`  
`project|Workshop LA 2019`

Purely personal. Names are proper nouns; keep original case.

*Dominant content colour?*

`color|red` `color|blue`  
`color|warm` `color|cold`  
`color|monochrome`  
`color|pastel` `color|muted`

Keep flat. Content colour is different from MAKI's editorial color-label field (5 fixed values).

*Ask: what distinct question does this answer?*

- New question → **top-level facet**.
- Refines an existing axis → **nest it**.
- Date-driven instance (weddings, trips) → top-level.
- Visual property (colour, tone) → top-level.
- Nameable & scoped (projects) → top-level.

Facets are cheap to add; wrong nesting is expensive to fix later.

## One photo, many facets a photo from Jane's 2025 wedding reception

**A single photo can intersect every facet. Each tag answers a different question about the same image:**

`subject|event|wedding`  
`subject|person|group`  
`subject|mood|joyful`  
`event|wedding-jane-2025`  
`location|Germany|Bayern|München`  
`person|friend|Alice M.`  
`technique|lighting|golden hour`  
`technique|style|documentary`  
`color|warm`

scene type  
composition  
mood  
specific occasion  
where  
who  
how lit  
how shot  
dominant colour

9 leaf tags across 7 facets. With ancestor expansion, ~15 tags stored. Search “`event:wedding-jane-2025 person:Alice color:warm`” intersects three orthogonal axes.

## Three places for event-related tags

three different questions, three different tags — they coexist on the same photo

|                                              |                                      |
|----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| <code>subject performing arts concert</code> | photo depicts a performance          |
| <code>subject event wedding</code>           | photo depicts a ceremony / gathering |
| <code>event wedding-jane-2025</code>         | photo is from this specific occasion |

A wedding photo can carry both `subject|event|wedding` and `event|wedding-jane-2025`. A concert photo fits under `subject|performing arts|concert`, not `subject|event|*`.

## Tag commands CLI and web UI share the same operations and the same semantics

|                                                |                                                               |
|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>maki tag ID foo bar</code>               | Add tags (ancestors auto-expanded).                           |
| <code>maki tag ID --remove foo</code>          | Remove tags (orphaned ancestors cleaned).                     |
| <code>maki tag clear ID</code>                 | Remove all tags from an asset.                                |
| <code>maki tag rename OLD NEW --apply</code>   | Rename a tag everywhere. Cascades to descendants.             |
| <code>maki tag delete TAG --apply</code>       | Delete a tag (and descendants) from every asset.              |
| <code>maki tag split OLD A B... --apply</code> | Replace one tag with multiple (variadic).                     |
| <code>... --keep</code>                        | Keep source alongside (additive / copy).                      |
| <code>maki tag expand-ancestors --apply</code> | Backfill ancestor paths on existing tags.                     |
| <code>maki tag fix-unicode --apply</code>      | NFC-normalise tag values; merges NFC/NFD duplicates.          |
| <code>maki tag export-vocabulary</code>        | Export the tag tree as <code>vocabulary.yaml</code> .         |
| <code>... --default</code>                     | Export the built-in starter vocabulary (ignores catalogue).   |
| <code>... --format text</code>                 | Tab-indented file for Lightroom / Capture One keyword import. |
| <code>... --format json</code>                 | Nested-object JSON with per-tag asset counts (for scripts).   |
| <code>... --counts</code>                      | In YAML, append <code># N assets</code> trailing comments.    |

|                                                 |                                       |
|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <code>tag:landscape</code>                      | Tag match at any level (default).     |
| <code>tag=:landscape</code>                     | Whole-path match (exact tag value).   |
| <code>tag:/landscape</code>                     | Leaf only at any level.               |
| <code>tag:^Landscape</code>                     | Case-sensitive.                       |
| <code>tag: wed</code>                           | Prefix anchor (wedding, wedding-...). |
| <code>-tag:rejected</code>                      | Exclude.                              |
| <code>tag:a,b</code>                            | Either a or b.                        |
| <code>tag:a tag:b</code>                        | Both a and b.                         |
| <code>event:jane person:Alice color:warm</code> | Intersect three facets.               |

Same filters work in CLI `maki search` and in the web UI search box.

